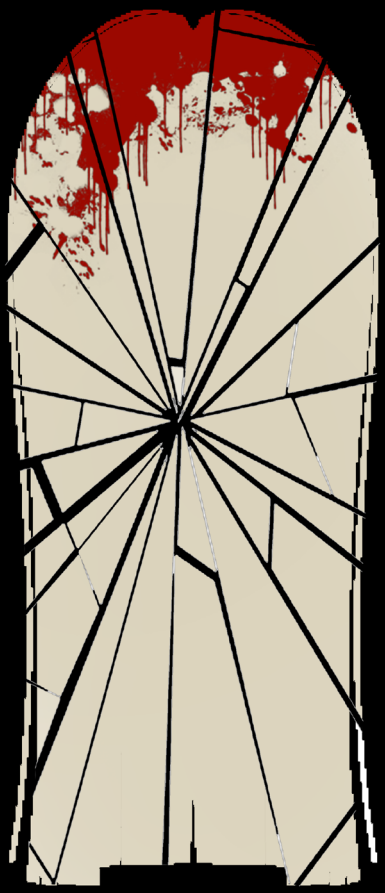
# Ophelia



Nicole Meenan

BA (Hons) Game Design and Production

# Information

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https://stripe-mascara-4cf.notion.site/1b6854cf14a4805f93ad-c779f7b5ced1?v=1b6854cf14a48115abfd000c5f7025b2

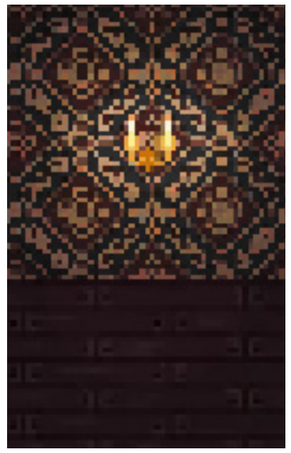
**Portfolio**
https://indd.adobe.com/view/ccf92841-79cd-43fa-903d-97316b0e38cc

**Play Ophelia**
https://nicolemeenan.itch.io/ophelia

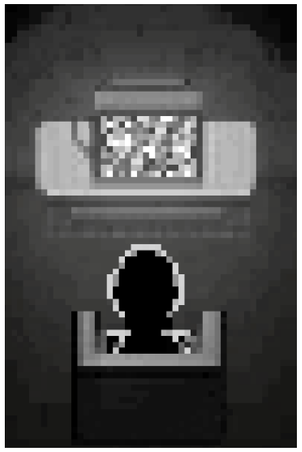


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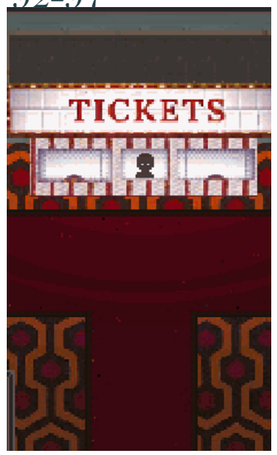


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# Pre - Production

## Project Aim

My practical prototype aims to be a playable criticism of the treatment of women by the games industry. In my research I explore why: gothic horror is an appropriate genre to comment on feminist issues, identify appropriate storytelling techniques to communicate the game's themes whilst keeping players captivated, finding and implementing design principles that are enticing to women, and thoroughly analyze current gender-issues to ensure I am versed enough on the subject to ethically pursue this project.

## Project Summary

The project was developed independently, I took responsibility for all visual art, narrative design, programming, production, and composition of an original sound. Through my research, I drew upon references to classic gothic media to engage players in a layered symbolic narrative. The final product is a synthesis of all my research, translated into practical work.

## Research Objectives

1. What is the connection between gothic horror and feminism?

2. How can intertextual referencing deepen a player's experience within a game?

3. Can games as expression invite more women into the gaming community?

# Context research

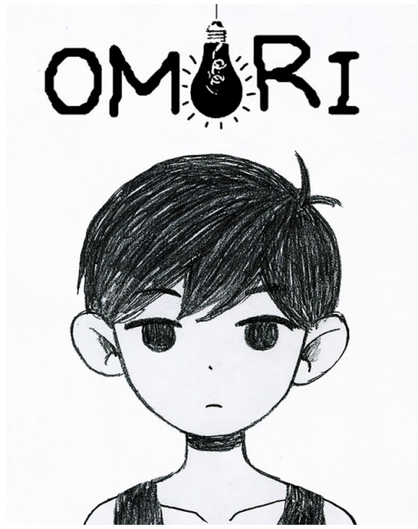
I decided on the name Ophelia for the name of the protagonist as well as the project. The name Ophelia was inspired by Hamlet's lover in the play *Hamlet*, who tragically spirals into madness and ultimately results into her drowning (Shakespeare, 1996). "Ophelia would have been understood as suffering from erotomania" (Wikipedia Contributors, 2019). Erotomania is a disease seen in mostly female patient's delusions of another person being infatuated with them. The focus of the delusion is usually a man who is deemed unattainable (Wikipedia, 2023). Ophelia is also of Greek origin derived from the word "help". "It's a fitting name for a character who ultimately causes her own downfall by not seeking help" (Howland, 2018). This is fitting for this project as one of the themes explored is feelings of helplessness.



(Wikipedia Contributors, 2023)



# Inspirations




(OMOCAT, 2022)

What birthed this project was my love for top-down RPG horror games that became popularised on *YouTube* around the 2010's. They often dealt with heavy themes and used surrealism and shock factor to express them. In 2020 a game called *Omori* was released (OMOCAT, 2020). It is an RPG horror game with a pixelated and pencil drawn art style - simple yet effective. This game is a masterclass of storytelling heavy themes and brought back my nostalgia for the genre. *Omori* uses emotions as a mechanic, has the perfect balance of beauty and horror, is atmospheric and will have you contemplating everything upon completion. The themes of escapism and dream worlds heavily influenced the narrative of my project. My research objectives of gender issues and gothic horror links into this approach seamlessly.

# Honorable Mentions

Made by wife-and-husband duo, *Fran Bow* (Killmonday Games, 2015) is a horror game that uses puzzles to help the main character Fran who is a 10-year-old girl struggling with childhood loss and truama. The balence between cute and creepy in this game has gameplay feeling like a fever dream. The storyline of this game is based on the designer's own personal life and struggles which is telling by the extremely raw delivery. Another great example of use of surrealism in horror.



(Wikipedia Contributors, 2023)

*Celeste* (Maddy Makes Games, 2018) follows a young woman forced to face her inner demons to reach the summit of a mountain. Differing from other games mentioned, *Celeste* is skill-based platformer and difficulty increases as the game progresses. This game has thoughtful symbolism and imagery which indicates emotional struggles that has been relatable to a wide range of audiences. The message of this game is that women are strong and can reach summits. Many other gender-based issues are depicted throughout too which makes it a great reference for my project.





(Hayden Dingman, 2018)

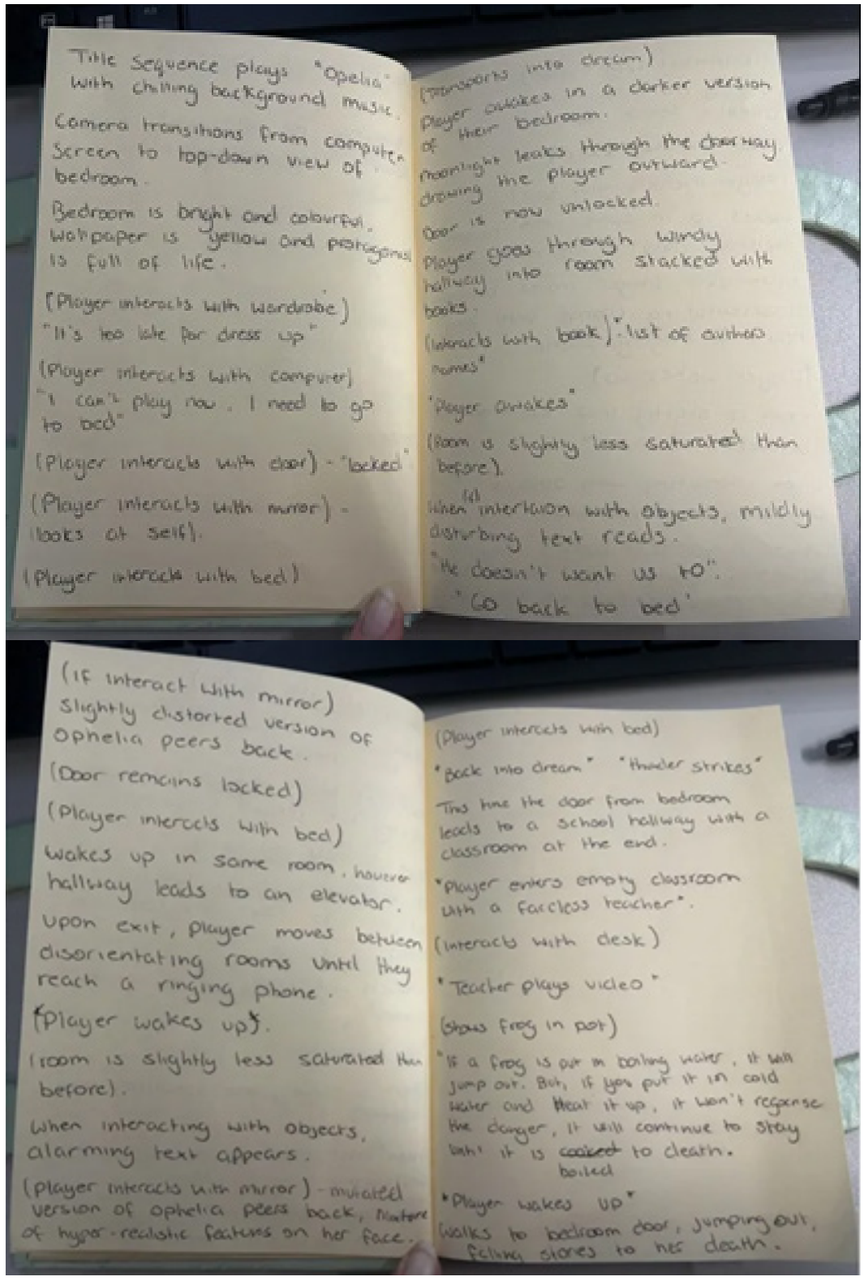
*Journey* (Thatgamecompany, 2012), produced by Robin Hunicke is an award-winning game that depicts a character travelling through a desert to reach a mountain in the distance. The selling point of this game is that you can encounter other players in real time on their journey, however you can only communicate through music notes. This game is designed to resonate emotionally with players and does within in a short, 90-minute gameplay. *Journey* is described as a game you feel rather than play which is a guiding point of my studies of captivating narrative.



(Keza MacDonald, 2012)

# Planning

After my I concluded my research, I wrote out a step-by-step as to how I wanted the games narrative to play out. This would later adapt and change as my skills and research progressed.




I then made a quick sketch of the floorplan to later help me in art production.

Key:

|| - doors

HOM - Hallway of Mirrors

HOD - Hallway of Doors

FH - Final Hallway

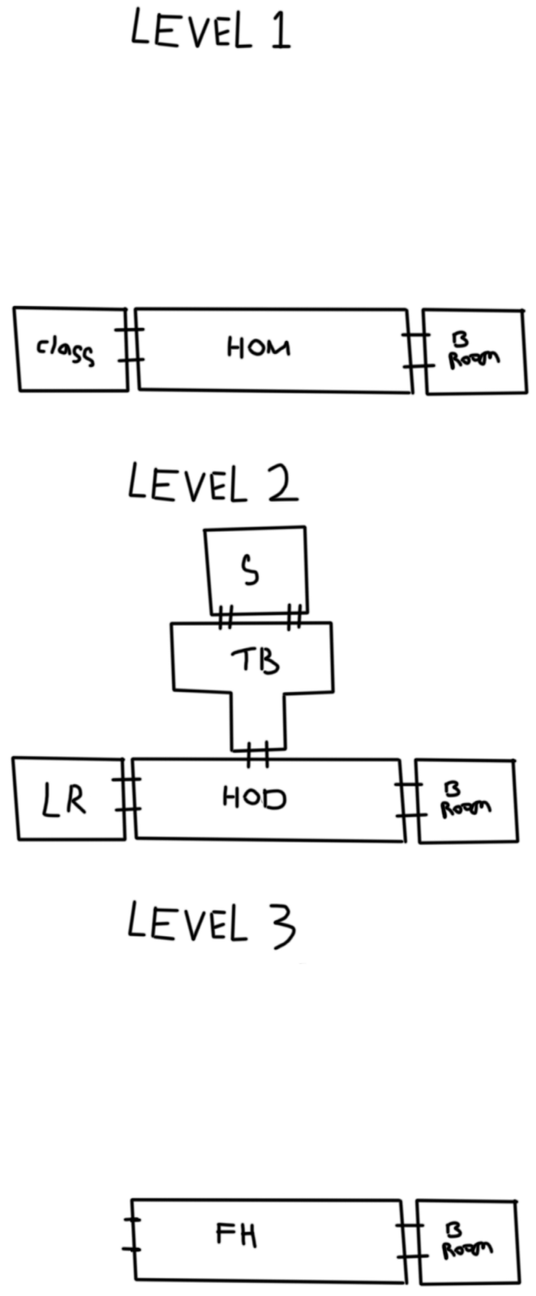
B-room - Bedroom

Class- Classrom

S - Stage

TB - TicketBooth

LR - Livingroom



Sprint

# One

# Art

# Production

# Visual Style

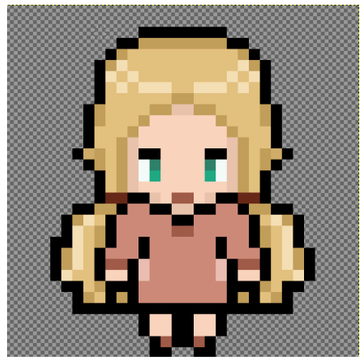
To honour my inspirations, I stayed true to the top-down pixel art style that many RPG horrors possess. This was a personal choice, driven by nostalgia.

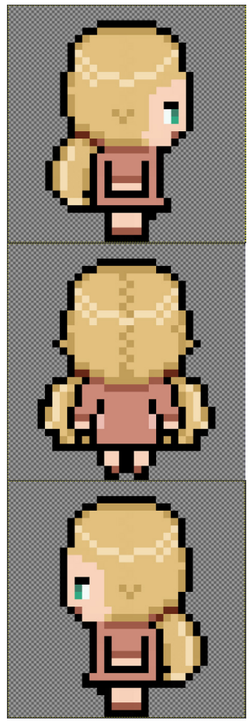


(Kikiyama, 2004)

# Character Design

This was the first version of my character design made the summer prior to 4th year. I had no experience in 2D art or the software '*Aseprite*' at this time. The character was loosely based off me, with little correlation to the narrative of the project.







I later revisited this design as my skills progressed and strived to design the character with more relevance to the themes and story. With the release of the film adaptation *Nosferatu* (2024), I based my character on the protagonist 'Ellen', who has a ghastly appearance and long dark hair, commonly seen in modern gothic films.

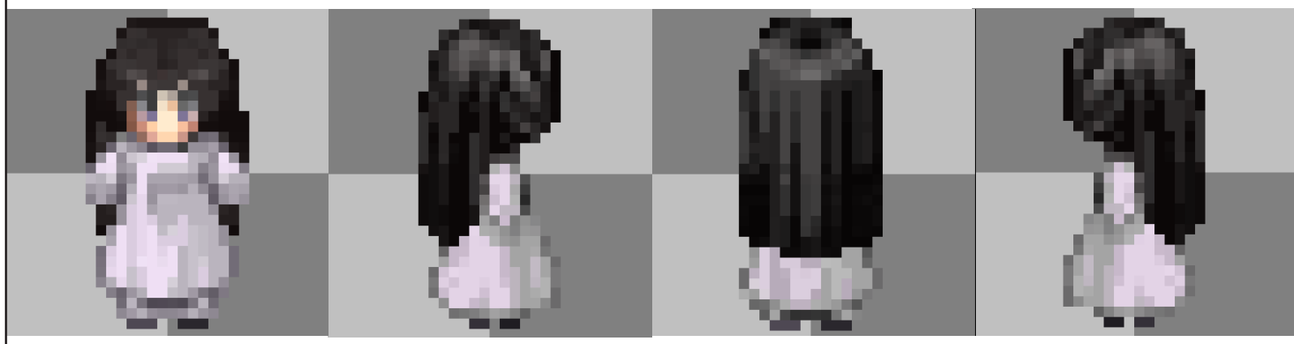


(Nosfertu, 2024)



(Poor Things, 2023)

I had to be cautious that the character would not appear out of place in any dream environment, since the visuals are inconsistent room-to-room (to further puzzle the player). Keeping colours minimal and desaturated achieved this, whilst aligning with the gothic style.



# Environment Art

## Bedroom

Since the bedroom is the first room the player sees, it is appropriate that it characterized aspects of the game that pioneered the RPG maker horror genre, cult classic *Yume Nikki* (Kikiyama, 2004). The game follows protagonist Madotsuki, who explores her surreal, nightmarish dreams. “Each dream begins in Madotsuki’s apartment, which appears similar to its waking world equivalent, aside from one important aspect: Madotsuki is able to leave through the front door” (Gaming the mind team, 2020). A clear inspiration and bases of my project.

The first bedroom design reflected a similar structure to Madotsuki’s, containing a bed, desk, rug and exit. This version was created at the same time as the first character iteration. It was later updated as my skills and research progressed.



(Kikiyama, 2004)



(First bedroom design)



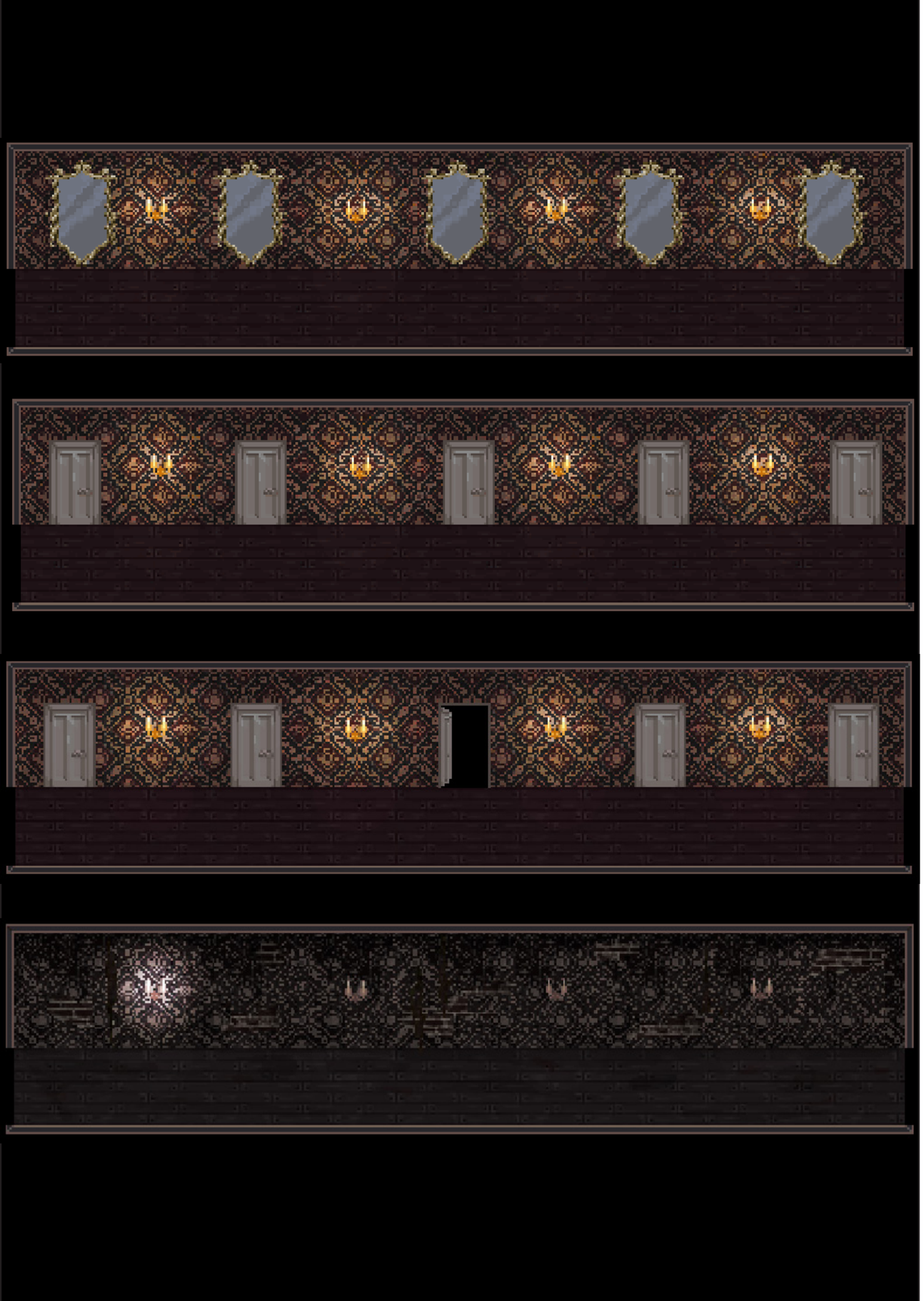
# Bedroom - iterated

In this second version, the bedroom is the players safe space, their sanctuary. It is cozy, colourful and cluttered, like many girls' rooms. the light rays bring comfort and safety, as well as informing the player that it is day approaching night. In contrast to this, the yellow wallpaper is a direct reference to Charlotte Perkins Gilam's short story "*The Yellow Wallpaper*" (Gilman, C. P., 1892), an early gothic feminist literature. It depicts a woman who is locked away in a nursery by her husband, where she increasingly obsesses and spirals over the yellow wallpaper. The story explores themes of  mental illness and gender roles, complementary to the themes within my game (Gilman, 2024).

# Bedroom - After Dark

In this room, I used basic level design principles by creating light to attract the player. The light spilling in by the doorway shows the player that this door is now open, and they are to go that way.





# Hallways

All hallways in the game are identical in size and shape, they are designed to perplex the player as they are ever-changing. The last hallway appears decrepit, with only one light to lead the player to their end.

# Classroom

The purpose of the classroom is to build on Ophelia's story, and to reflect on crucial relationship which has shaped her life - her teacher. The classroom represents Ophelia's innocence and vulnerability, a setting where she was most impressionable. Horror lies in the corruption of a place of learning and suggests imbalance of power. Classrooms are a place of control, emphasising on Ophelia's lack of self-assurance. It also relates to the audience, since almost everyone has been a student in their lives, increasing the likeliness that the player will project themselves onto the character (Sam, 2024). This was a thoughtful choice, contrasting safety and danger.

The distortion of the teacher shows the player that Ophelia's mind is struggling to recall the memory, as it's too painful. This creates an eerie 'glitch' in the silhouette. Character design of NPC's is noteworthy, they all consist of a black silhouette, with no distinctive features. This is to show the player that although memories can fade and change, their physical and mental affects prevail.



# Livingroom

As the game progresses, the player enters a dark room void of colour, only lit by television static. This room highlights Ophelia's invisibility to the world, the NPC would rather watch static than acknowledge her presence. The inspiration was drawn from the game *PARASiTE FLOWER*, a heartbreaking depiction of the horrors of girlhood.



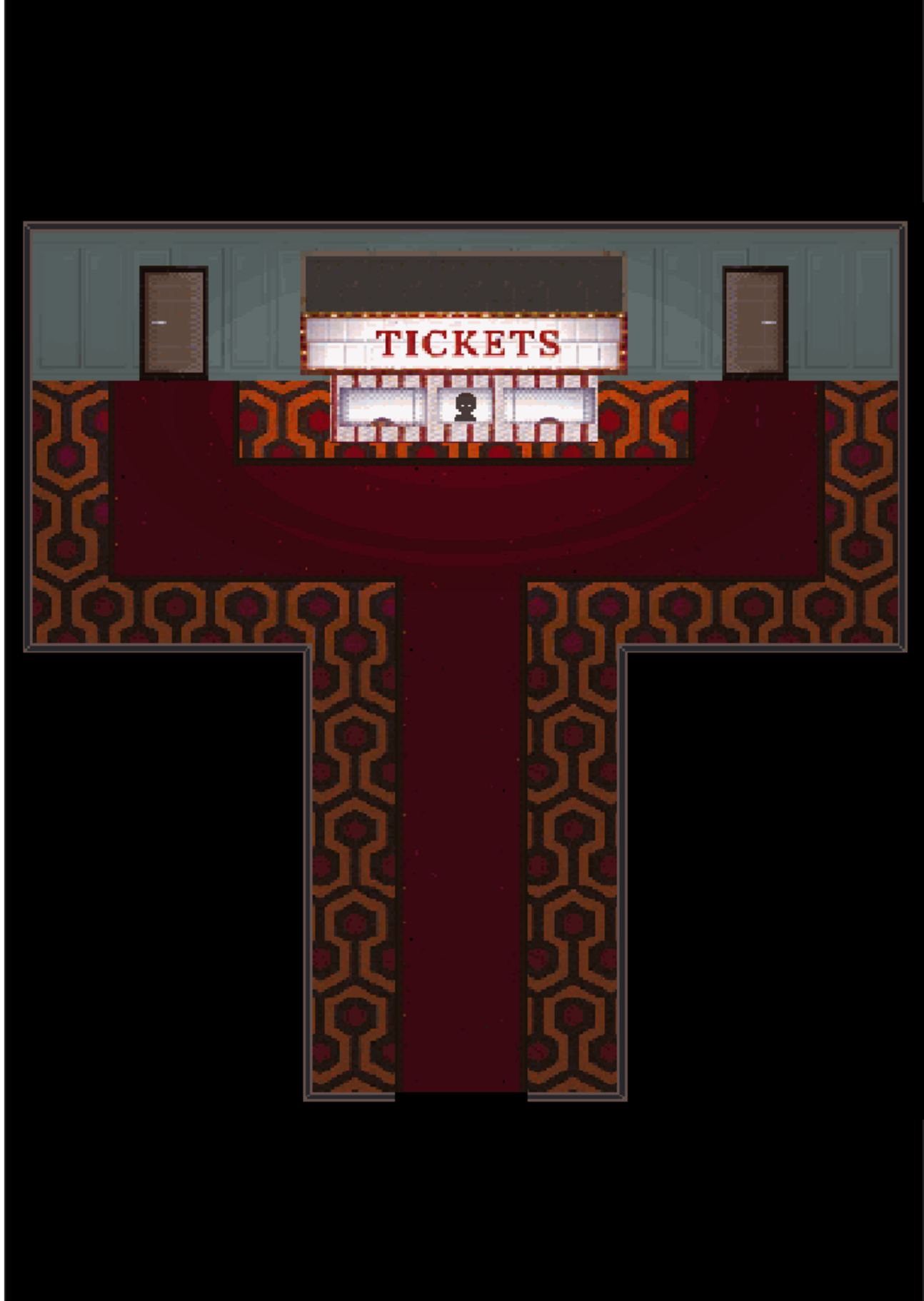
(Catowo, 2024)

# Ticket Booth

This room purpose is mainly to build up tension before the game's climax. The player is led to the booth by flashing lights, and then toward the doors, both leading to the stage. The carpet design is in reference to the iconic horror film '*The Shining*' (The Shining, 1980) based off  the book by Stephen King.



(The Shining, 1980)



# Stage

The stage is where the game reaches its climax. Ophelia is stuck under the spotlight, unable to move. The crowd demands her to perform as a gentle melody progresses to chaos. This represents the exhausting and humiliating demands of women from society. The scene parallels that of the horror film *Carrie* (Carrie, 1976), another Stephen King adaptation.



(Carrie, 1976)

The idea around the stage scene is based upon an analogy of a ballerina in a music box which full circles back to the initial aim of my project – depicting the woman experience. The ballerina is beautiful, admired from afar, and is trapped within the walls of her box. Every time the sweet melody plays, she dances, expected to perform without question. Her strength lies in the fact she keeps on dancing, despite her tragic fate. A message to women everywhere who claim their right to dance freely, regardless of the societal expectation set before them.

# Inside the photoframe

Later in the process I repurposed an old piece of  art to create this dark corridor with light spilling in from the door. This was to fill in a narrative gap that I had between the Livingroom and the next Bedroom. In this room, Ophelia experiences a version of  herself  chase her towards the door.



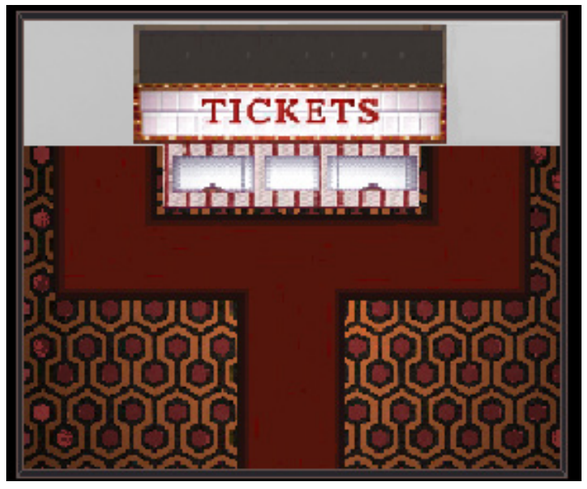
# Disregarded Art

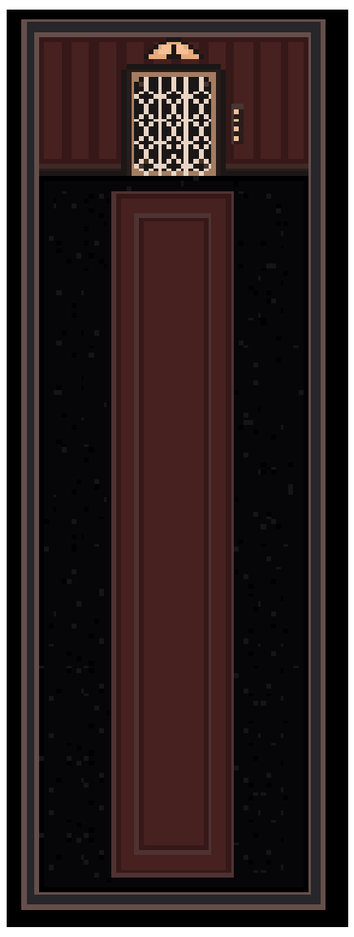
Art created that didn't appear in the final prototype either due to it being the wrong size/scale, it no longer fitting with the adapting narrative, or not being up to the standard I set for this project.

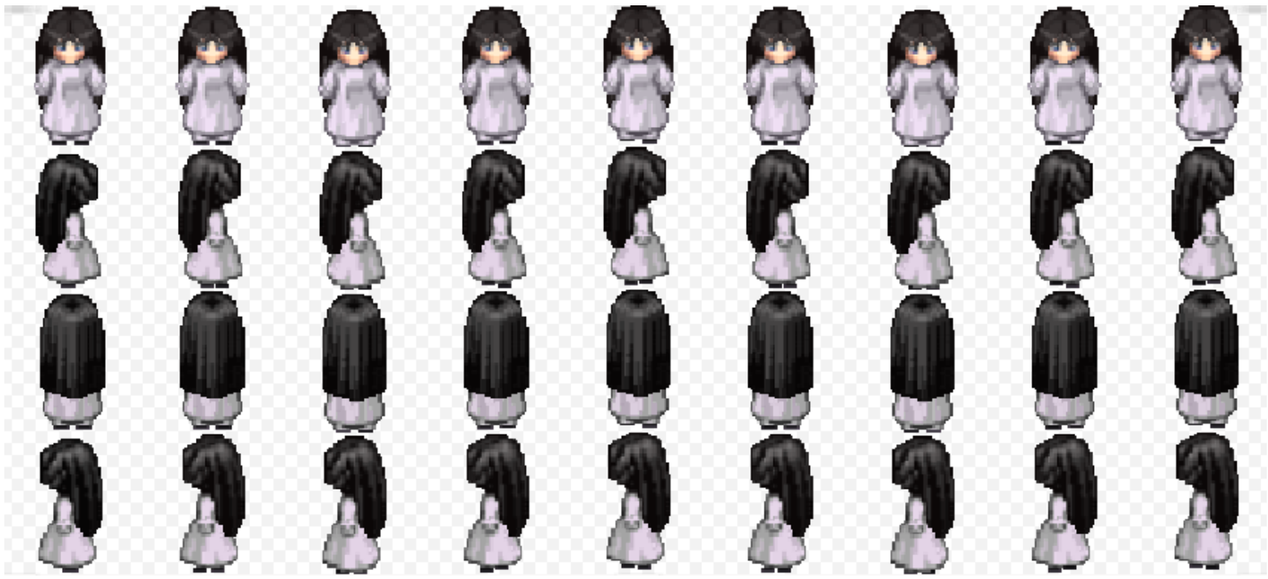


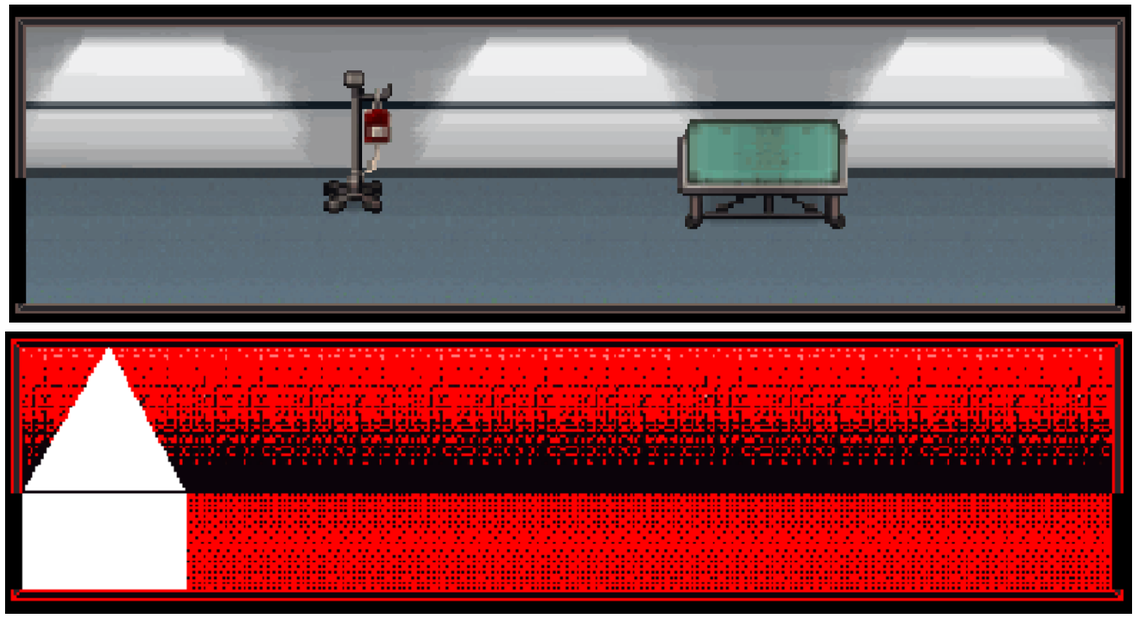


















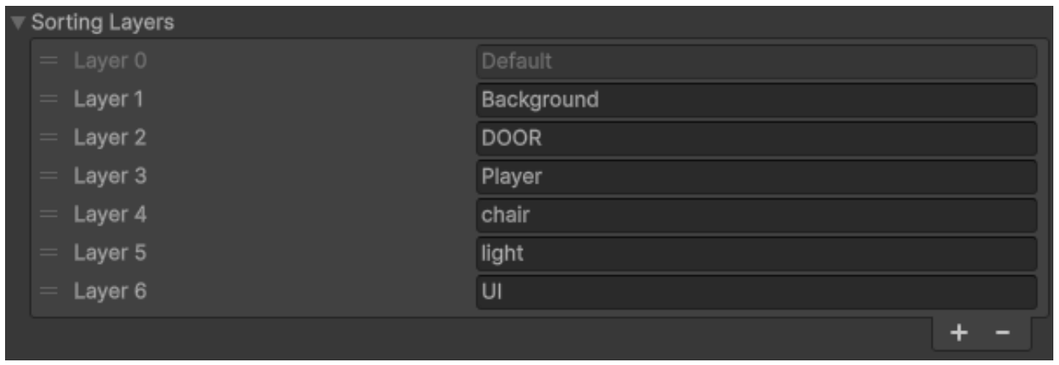
Sprint

# Two

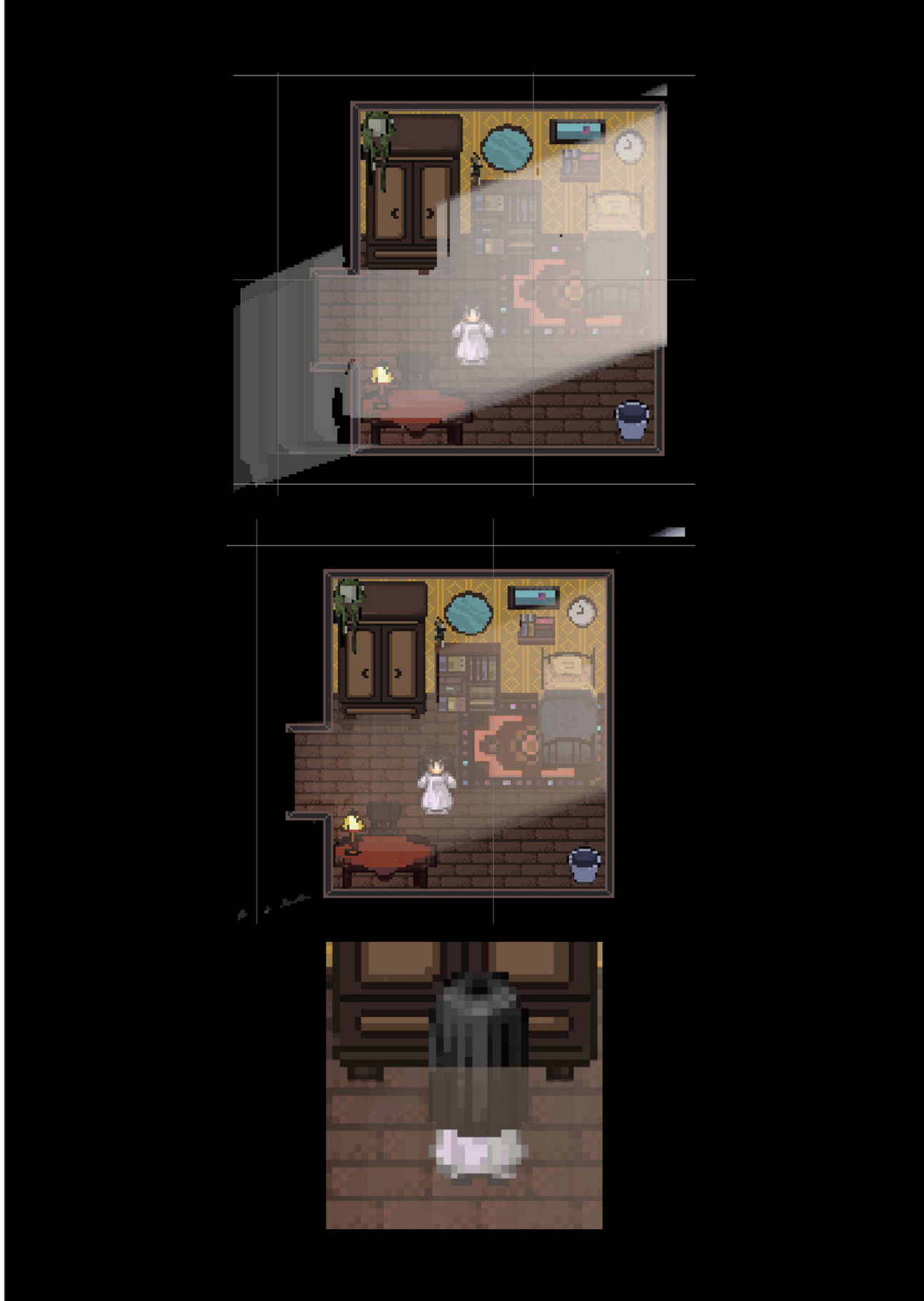
# Programming And Implementation

# Importing art

Straight away I seen flaws in my practice. I made most of my environment art without bringing it into engine to test it. The opacity of the lighting appeared much stronger in the editor than it did in *Aseprite*. I also realised things like lighting would need to be exported as separate assets so I could layer them above the player.




To resolve this, I went back into *Aseprite* and lowered the opacity of the light much lower and carefully erased any overflow around the rooms borders. I later discovered I can change opacity of objects in unity and this saved further hassle.



```
Unity Script (1 asset reference) | 0 references
public class playerMovement : MonoBehaviour
{
    public float moveSpeed = 1f;

    public Rigidbody2D rb;
    public Animator animator;
    public bool canMove;

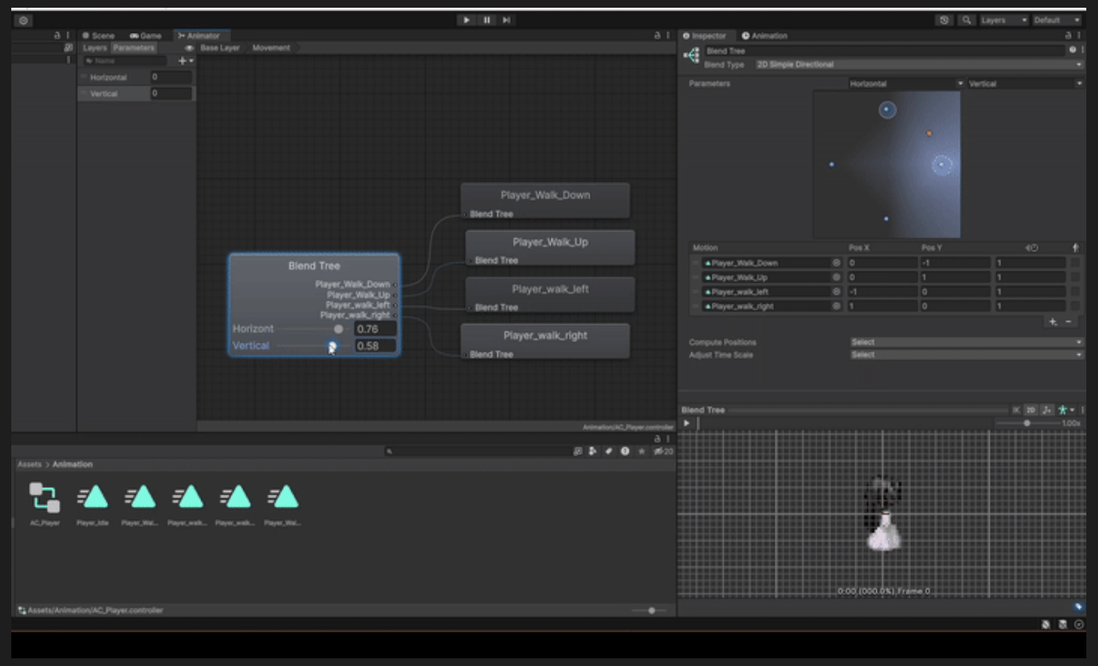
    public AudioSource footSteps;

    Vector2 movement;

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Start()
    {
        rb = GetComponent<Rigidbody2D>();
        canMove = true;
    }
    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Update()
    {
        movement.x = Input.GetAxisRaw("Horizontal");
        movement.y = Input.GetAxisRaw("Vertical");

        if (canMove && moveSpeed != 0f)
        {
            animator.SetFloat("Horizontal", movement.x);
            animator.SetFloat("Vertical", movement.y);
            animator.SetFloat("Speed", movement.sqrMagnitude);
        }
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void FixedUpdate()
    {
        rb.MovePosition(rb.position + movement * moveSpeed * Time.fixedDeltaTime);
    }
```

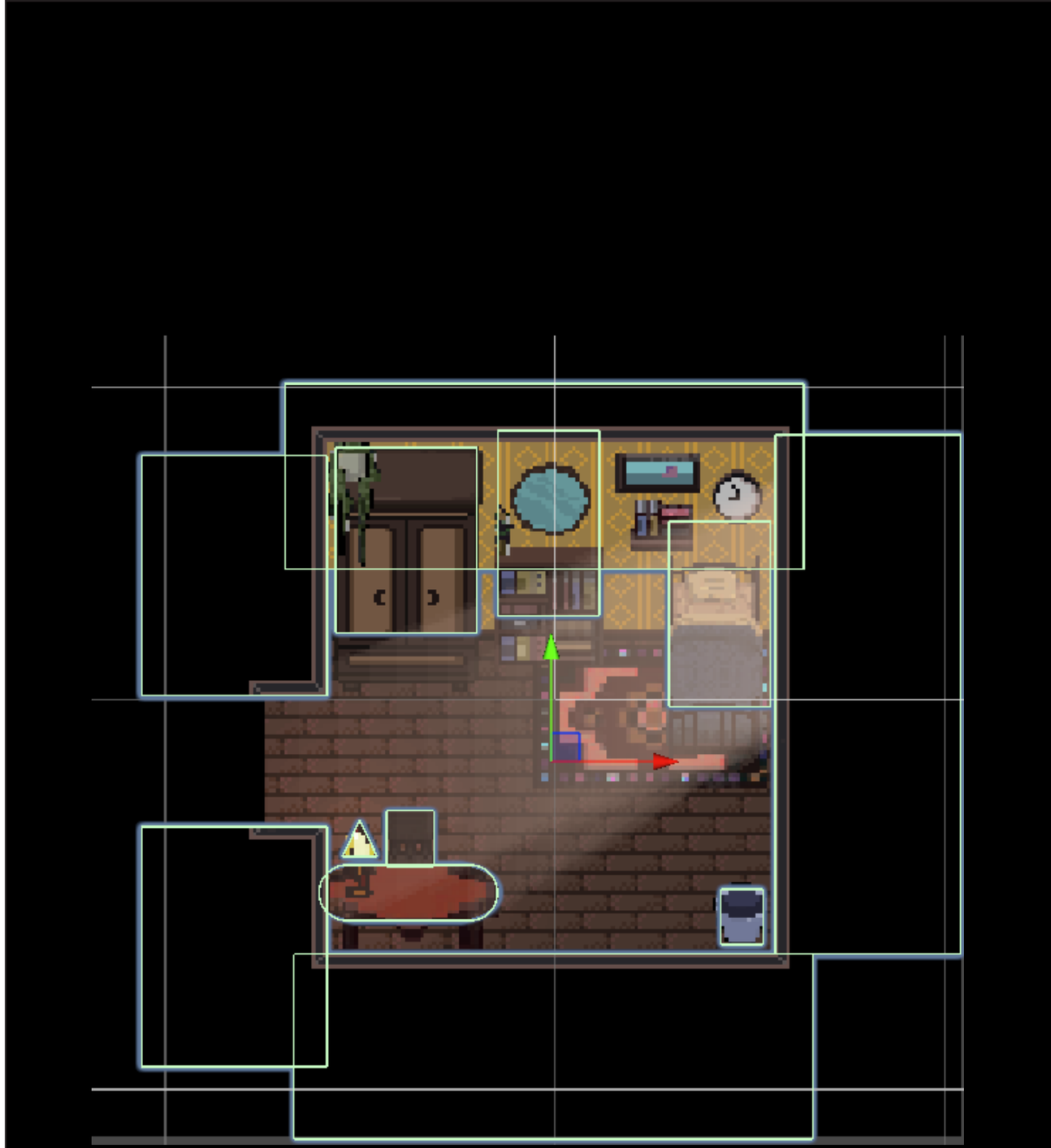



# Player Controller

The first script I wrote was for character movement. Using the animation system in *Unity* I was able to implement my sprite sheet and use the "blend tree" tool to create a seamless animation, having the player face the right direction depending on which input is pressed by the player. Within the script, I used the "FixedUpdate" function to execute movement since using a physics element (Rigidbody2D).

# Boundaries

To create areas that the player could not enter, I created 2D sprites, scaled them accordingly, then layered them behind the background as to not be seen, and gave them a “Boxcollider2D” component, meaning that the player will collide with these objects and not surpass them. I rinsed and repeated this technique for all the environments within the game



```
Unity Script (40 asset references) | 0 references
public class Sign : MonoBehaviour
{

    public Signal contextOn;
    public Signal contextOff;
    public GameObject dialogBox;
    public Text dialogText;
    public string dialog;
    public bool playerInRange;

    Unity Message | 0 references
    void Update()
    {
        if (Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E) && playerInRange)
        {
            if (dialogBox.activeInHierarchy)
            {
                dialogBox.SetActive(false);
            }
            else
            {
                dialogBox.SetActive(true);
                dialogText.text = dialog;
            }
        }
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnTriggerEnter2D(Collider2D other)
    {
        if (other.CompareTag("Player"))
        {
            contextOn.Raise();
            playerInRange = true;
        }
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnTriggerExit2D(Collider2D other)
    {
        if (other.CompareTag("Player"))
        {
            contextOff.Raise();
            playerInRange = false;
            dialogBox.SetActive(false);

        }
    }
}
```

```
Unity Script (1 asset reference) | 0 references
public class ContextClue : MonoBehaviour
{
    public GameObject contextClue;

    0 references
    public void Enable()
    {
        contextClue.SetActive(true);
    }

    0 references
    public void Disable()
    {
        contextClue.SetActive(false);
    }
}
```

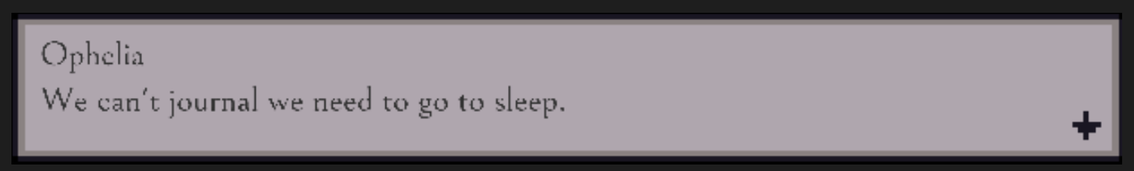
```
Unity Script (2 asset references) | 4 references
public class SignalListener : MonoBehaviour
{

    public Signal signal;
    public UnityEvent signalEvent;

    1 reference
    public void OnSignalRaised()
    {
        signalEvent.Invoke();
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnEnable()
    {
        signal.RegisterListener(this);
    }
    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnDisable()
    {
        signal.DeRegisterListener(this);
    }
}
```




# Dialogue Sytem 1

This was by far the most challenging part of the programming process. I followed hours upon hours of tutorials that either broke parts of my already implemented components or weren't compatible with my desired function of the game. Due to my limited coding knowledge, I wasn't very good at troubleshooting issues I was getting so I would just start fresh using different techniques until one worked.

The first type of dialogue I needed was when the player interacted with their environment. First of all, they needed a prompt to know when to interact. I created a small UI element telling the player what button to press to interact. Then I use "Signals" which would trigger this on or off depending on if the player is in range of an interactable object. If E is pressed, the dialogue box would be activated in the hierarchy containing the relevant text.

# Dialogue Sytem 2

Later I would need a dialogue system that was able to hold longer texts that players could click through. I first tried adapting the first system to accommodate for this but after many failures i created a new one.

This script allowed me to write as many lines of  text as needed, had a typewriter-like effect and lets the player to skip through, and once the last line is read, the next scene is loaded. This was ideal for the cutscene-like segments my game contains.

```
public class Dialogue : MonoBehaviour
{
    public Text textComponent;
    public string[] lines;
    public float textSpeed;

    private int index;

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Start()
    {
        textComponent.text = string.Empty;
        StartDialogue();
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Update()
    {
        if(Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E))
        {
            if(textComponent.text == lines[index])
            {
                NextLine();
            }
            else
            {
                StopAllCoroutines();
                textComponent.text = lines[index];

            }
        }
    }

    1 reference
    void StartDialogue()
    {
        index = 0;
        StartCoroutine(TypeLine());
    }

    2 references
    IEnumerator TypeLine()
    {
        foreach (char c in lines[index].ToCharArray())
        {
            textComponent.text += c;
            yield return new WaitForSeconds(textSpeed);
        }
    }

    1 reference
    void NextLine()
    {
        if(index < lines.Length - 1)
        {
            index++;
            textComponent.text = string.Empty;
            StartCoroutine(TypeLine());
        }
        else
        {
            gameObject.SetActive(false);
            Invoke("MoveOn", 3f);
        }
    }


    0 references
    void MoveOn()
    {
        SceneManager.LoadScene(SceneManager.GetActiveScene().buildIndex + 1);
        Debug.Log("completed");
    }
}
```

```
Unity Message | 0 references
private void Update()
{
    if (inBed == true && Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E))
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo());
    }
    else if (inBed2 == true && Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E))
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo2());
    }
    else if (inBed3 == true && Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E))
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo4());
    }
    else if (door == true && Input.GetKeyDown(KeyCode.E))
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo5());
    }
}
```

```
Unity Message | 0 references
private void OnTriggerEnter2D(Collider2D collision)
{
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "BedroomDoor1")
    {
        SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("HallwayOfMirrors");
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "BedroomDoor2")
    {
        SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("HallwayOfDoors");
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "BedroomDoor3")
    {
        SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Opendoor");
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "BedroomDoor4")
    {
        SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("HosHallway 1");
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "Bed")
    {
        inBed = true;
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "Bed2")
    {
        inBed2 = true;
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "Bed3")
    {
        inBed3 = true;
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "HOM")
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo6());
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "DoorOpen")
    {
        StartCoroutine(FadeCo3());
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "HOD")
    {
        SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Livingroom");
    }
    if (collision.gameObject.tag == "StageDoor")
    {
        door = true;
    }
```

```
public IEnumerator FadeCo3()
{
    if (fadeOutPanel != null)
    {
        Instantiate(fadeOutPanel, Vector3.zero, Quaternion.identity);
    }
    yield return new WaitForSeconds(fadeWait);
    AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Stage");
    while (!asyncOperation.isDone)
    {
        yield return null;
    }
}

1 reference
public IEnumerator FadeCo4()
{
    if (fadeOutPanel != null)
    {
        Instantiate(fadeOutPanel, Vector3.zero, Quaternion.identity);
    }
    yield return new WaitForSeconds(fadeWait);
    AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Bedroom5");
    while (!asyncOperation.isDone)
    {
        yield return null;
    }
}

1 reference
public IEnumerator FadeCo5()
{
    if (fadeOutPanel != null)
    {
        Instantiate(fadeOutPanel, Vector3.zero, Quaternion.identity);
    }
    yield return new WaitForSeconds(fadeWait);
    AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Tickets");
    while (!asyncOperation.isDone)
    {
        yield return null;
    }
}

1 reference
public IEnumerator FadeCo6()
{
    if (fadeOutPanel != null)
    {
        Instantiate(fadeOutPanel, Vector3.zero, Quaternion.identity);
    }
    yield return new WaitForSeconds(fadeWait);
    AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Classroom0");
    while (!asyncOperation.isDone)
    {
        yield return null;
    }
}

1 reference
IEnumerator MoveOn()
{
    yield return new WaitForSeconds(8f);
    AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Bedroom4");

}
```

# Scene Management

This very chaotic script controls the fade-in/fade-out effect in my game and detects collision on doors to move onto the next scene. This is by no means an efficient way to code these functionalities, however, with my minimal coding experience this is just what made sense in my mind and what worked for me. In no way was this project meant to be a product of optimal coding, it just needed to work, which it does.for the cutscene-like segments my game contains.

# Music Manager

This script uses the 'DontDestroyOnLoad' function to carry the ambient sounds between both classroom scenes, then destroys the object (stops the sound) when the next scene is loaded.

```
public class DDOL : MonoBehaviour
{
    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Awake()
    {
        DontDestroyOnLoad(gameObject);
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Update()
    {

    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnEnable()
    {
        SceneManager.sceneLoaded += OnSceneLoaded;
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void OnDisable()
    {
        SceneManager.sceneLoaded -= OnSceneLoaded;
    }

    2 references
    void OnSceneLoaded(Scene scene, LoadSceneMode mode)
    {
        SceneNameShower(scene.name);
        if(SceneManager.GetActiveScene().name == "scaryroom")
        {
            Destroy(gameObject);
        }
    }

    1 reference
    void SceneNameShower(string scenename)
    {
        Debug.Log("OnSceneLoaded; " + scenename);
    }
}
```

```
Unity Script (3 asset references) | 0 references
public class MoveTo : MonoBehaviour
{
    public GameObject title1;
    public GameObject title2;
    public float speed;
    public bool canMove;

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Start()
    {
        canMove = false;
        StartCoroutine(Move());
    }

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Update()
    {
        if(canMove == true)
        title1.transform.position = Vector3.MoveTowards(title1.transform.position, title2.transform.position, speed);
    }

    1 reference
    IEnumerator Move()
    {
        while (true)
        {

            yield return new WaitForSeconds(3f);
            canMove = true;
        }
    }
}
```

# “Move to” script

This script takes one game object and moves it to the position of another game object. I used this script to create the chase in photo frame scene and to give UI elements an animation effect in title and credits screens.

Sprint

# Three

# Narrative, Design And Storytelling

# Dialogue

## Interactable Objects

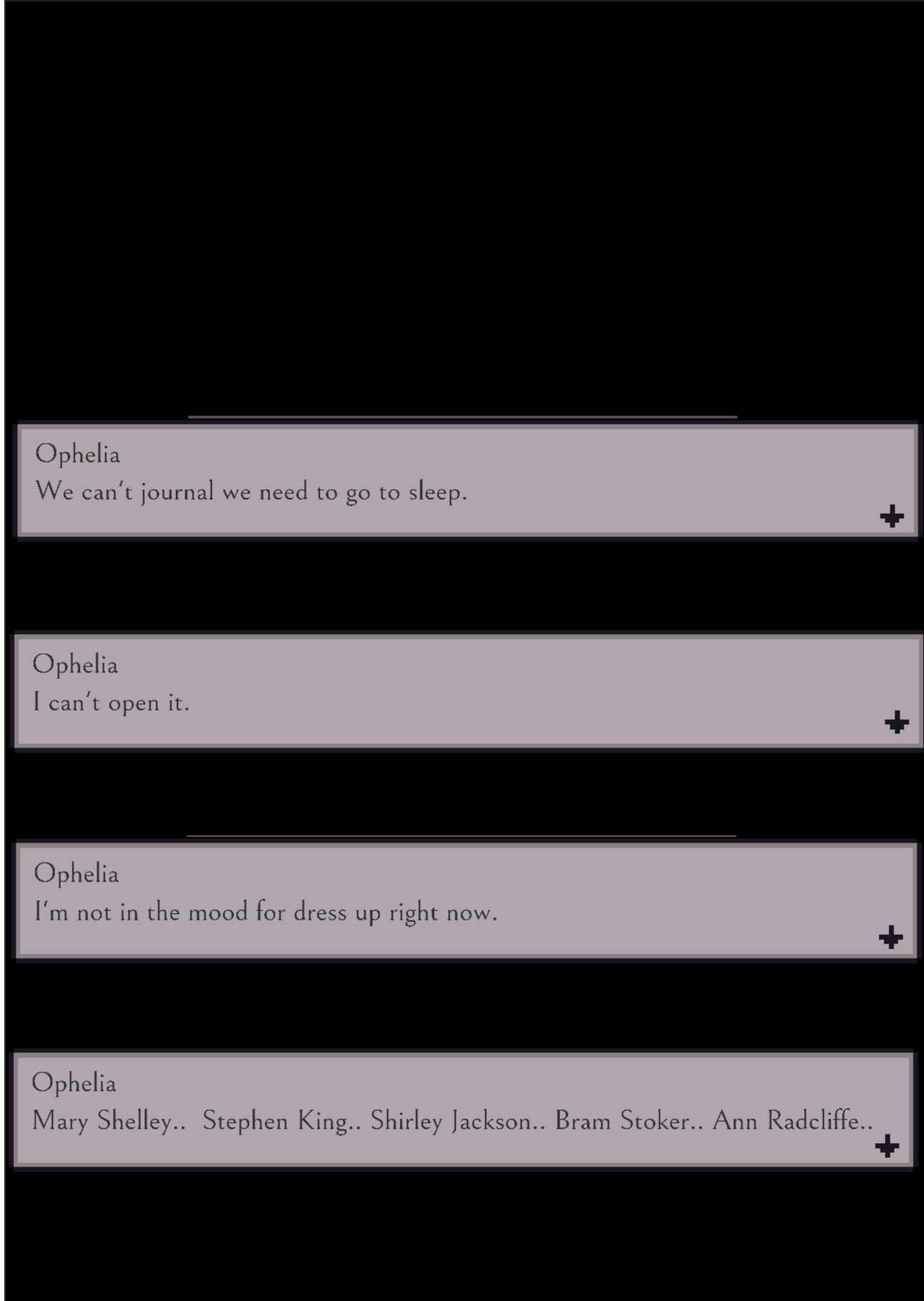
To give the player guidence on what to do.

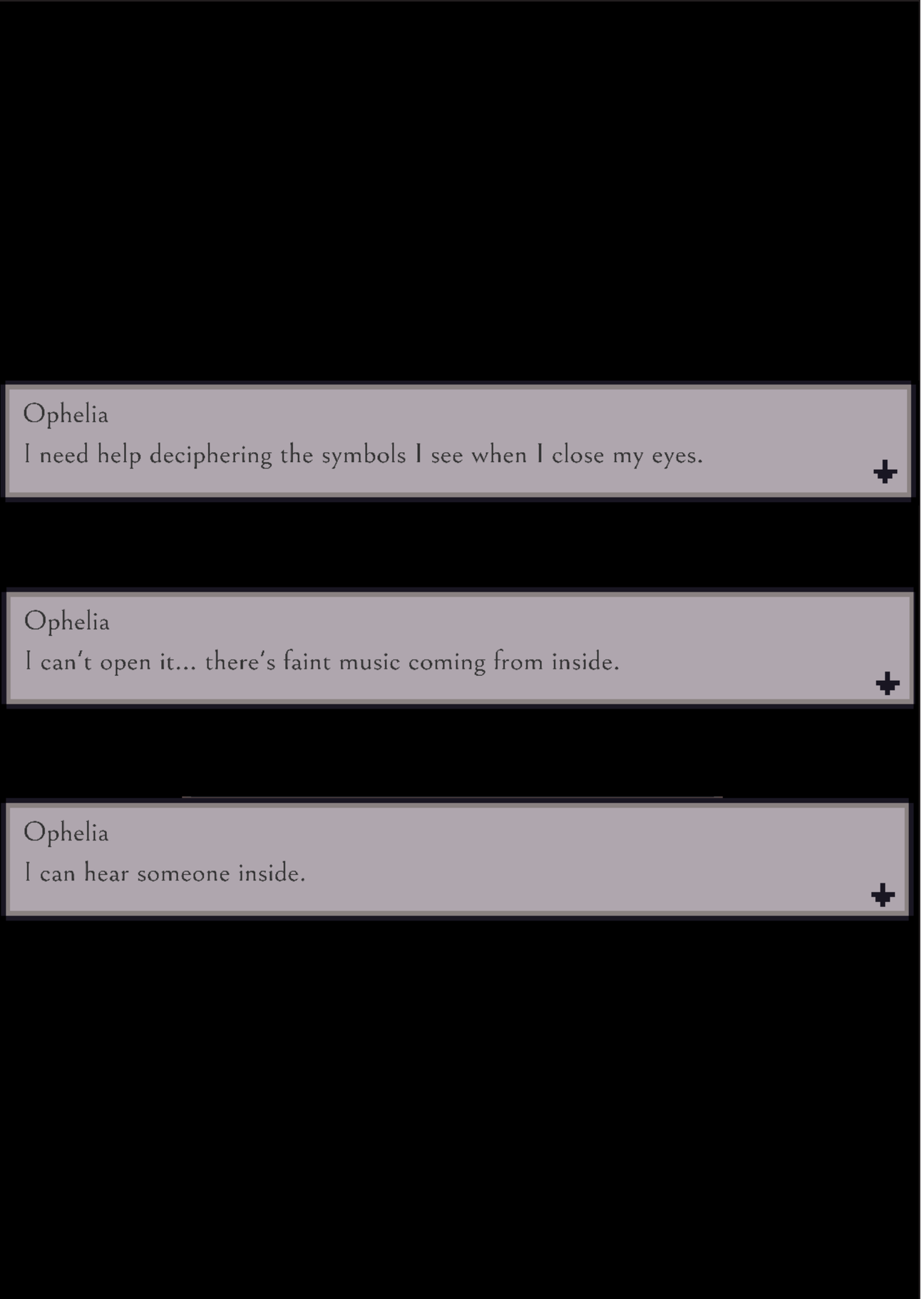
Uses deliberate self-deprecating language. Instead of the standard "It's locked", Ophelia sees the locked door as a weakness of herself, since she's unable to open it. This sets the tone for themes of helplessness throughout the game.

This line is to show the demise of Ophelia's light and innocence. It also plays to her femininity as dress up is commonly enjoyed by young girls. A slight alludes at old flash games centred around dressing a character.

An appreciation to the authors that shaped my project and that pioneered the gothic horror genre.








An eerie change of tone, foreshadows the collage of symbols shown in the short scene after interacting with the teacher. Suggests Ophelia is struggling with mental illness.

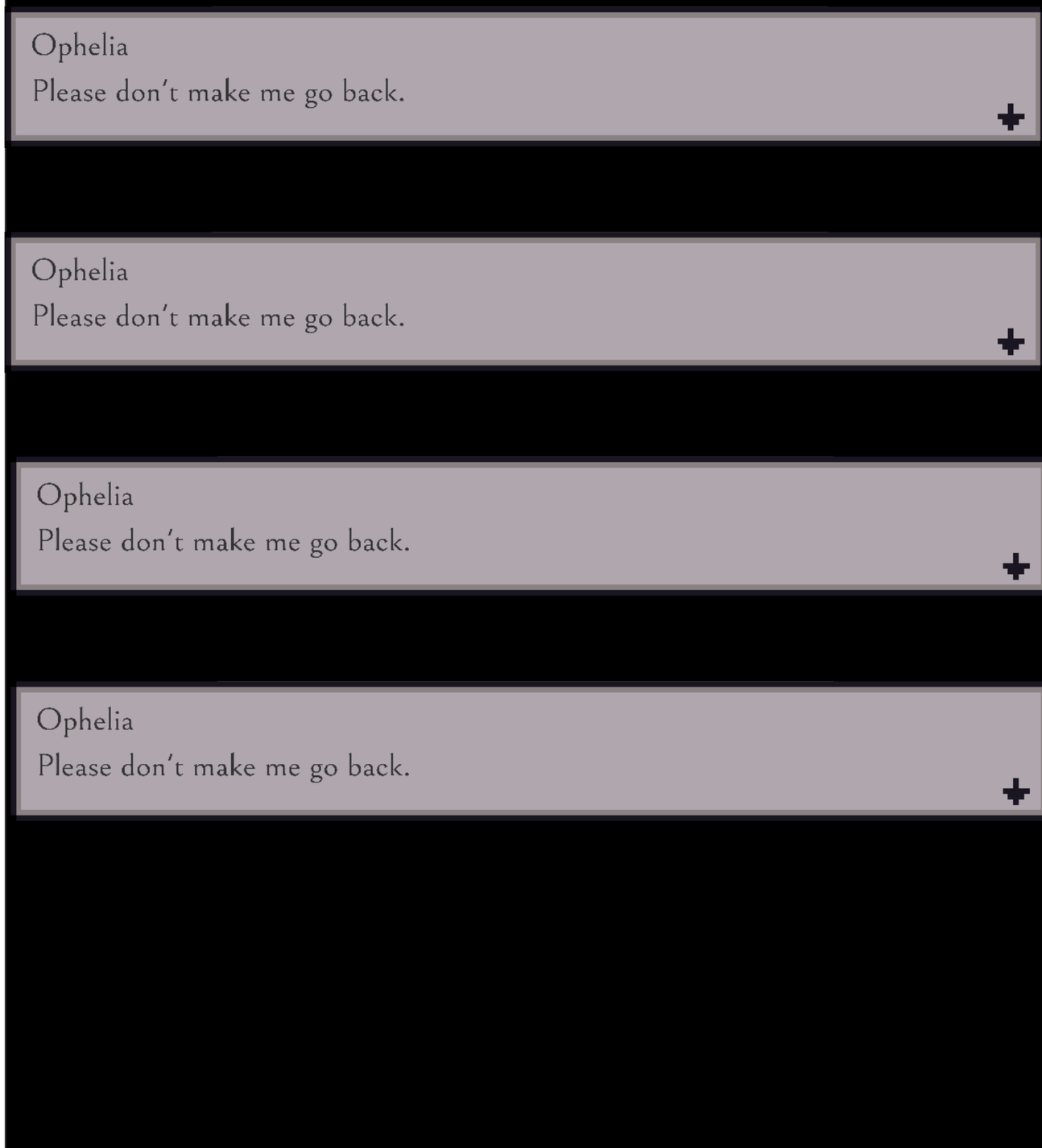
Tells the player they are later to progress through that locked door.

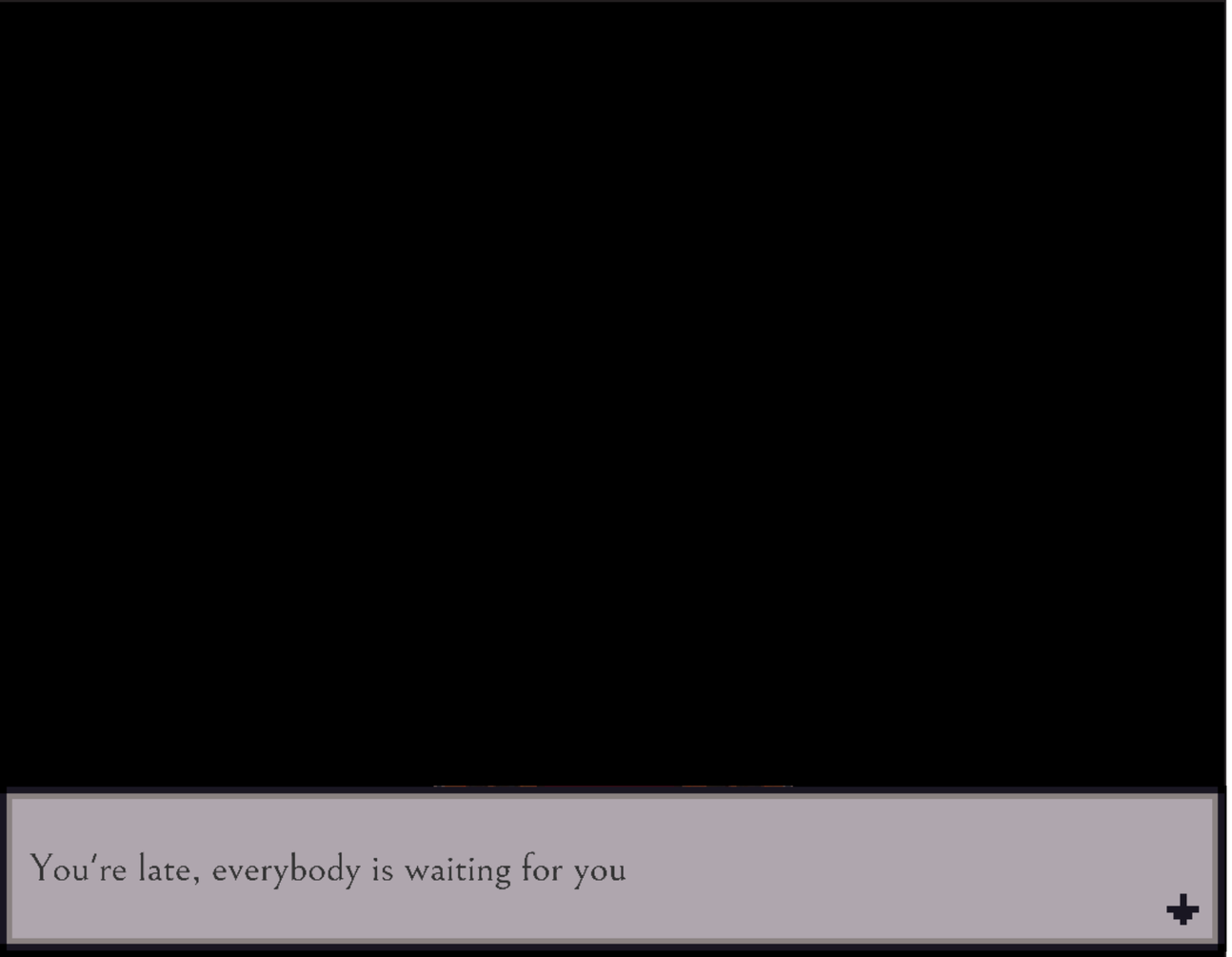
Horrifying line shows that Ophelia may be in danger in her own bedroom, her safe space.

All interactable objects in the bedroom of the third sequence read the same thing. Ophelia pleads with the player not to go back into her dreams, as she knows it's going to lead to her demise. However, the player has no choice other than to progress through the game by going back to sleep. This is on the lead up to the games climax, weighing in on the themes of helplessness. This particular line was inspired by a dialogue seen in *Lacy Games*, a huge influence of mine. Lacy, similarly, pleads to the player not to make her go outside where her attacker awaits, followed by the chilling line "what have you done".



(ghosttundra, 2025)






This stand-alone piece of dialogue is found in the tickets room, before the climax. The sentence is short and brash, even in Ophelia's own dreams, people aren't warm to her. It was written to spark a slight anxiety, a sense of rush, and a build up to the following scene.

Similarly to the last dialogue, all interactable objects in the final bedroom sequence read the same thing. A jumbled-up font reading “escape” over and over again. Now Ophelia can open her bedroom door, she can escape. The letters appear this way as it anticipates the breaking of  the 4th wall to come in the following scene. The breaking down of  the system, perhaps.



Okay class today we're going to talk about invisibility.

Ophelia stop interupting.

...Can anyone tell me what it is we cannot see?

No one?

Invisibility is all around you.

Can't you feel it?

Lets move on.

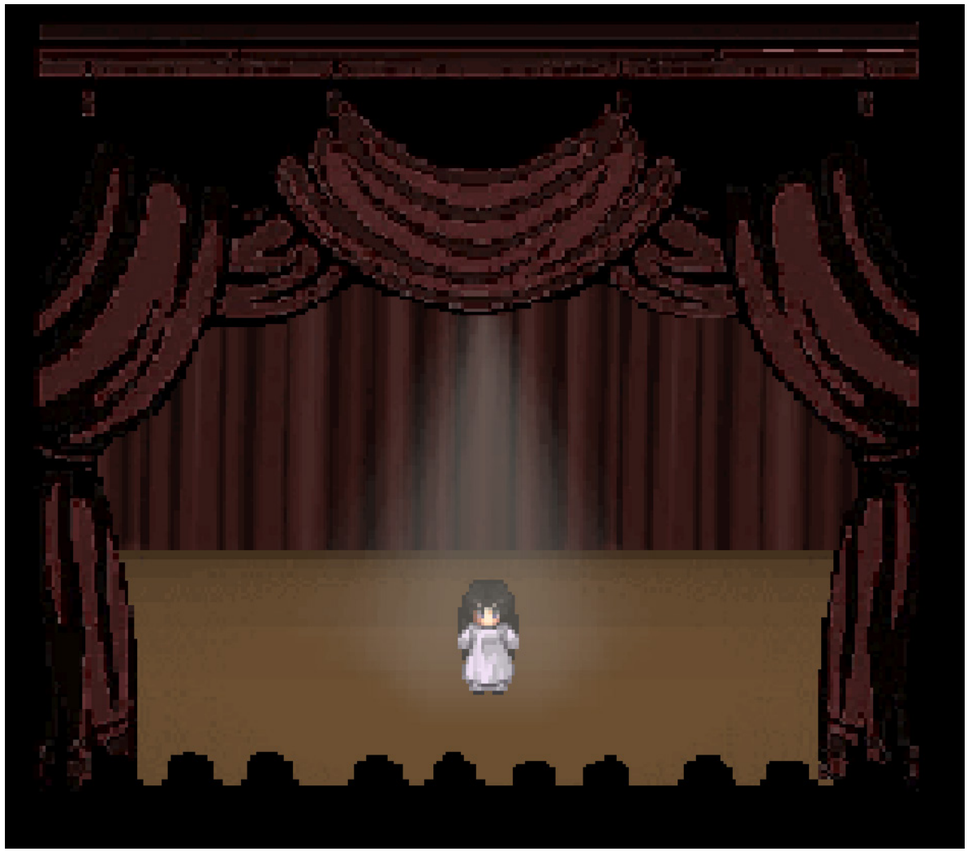
This isn't real.

# Dialogue

## Cutscenes



Lines of dialogue found in the classroom cutscene. I used experiences in my own dreams as style reference, how conversations with people can often seem disconnected, and erratic. This cryptic script alludes to the invisibility that Ophelia feels. She recalls this particular event in her dreams since classrooms are a critical environment in children's development, something may have happened there to cause her to be having this nightmare. She is belittled by her teacher, telling her to stop interrupting, despite her silence - an abuse of power. This is to further show her feelings of being misunderstood.



Lines of dialogue found in the stage scene. An analogy of a ballerina in a music box which full circles back to the initial aim of my project – expressing the women experience. The line "trapped within the glass walls of her confinement" foreshadows the ending where she jumps out of the scene, followed by a smashing sound, breaking free of this game where she is subject to relive her trauma. Her strength lies in the fact she keeps on 'dancing', despite her tragic fate. A message to women, who claim their right to dance freely, regardless of the societal expectation set before them.



A ballerina inside a music box.

dancing gracefully to a tune that never changes.

Her moves are delicate, and precise.

She is beautiful, to be admired from afar,

but trapped within the glass walls of her confinement.

Evertime the music plays, she dances,

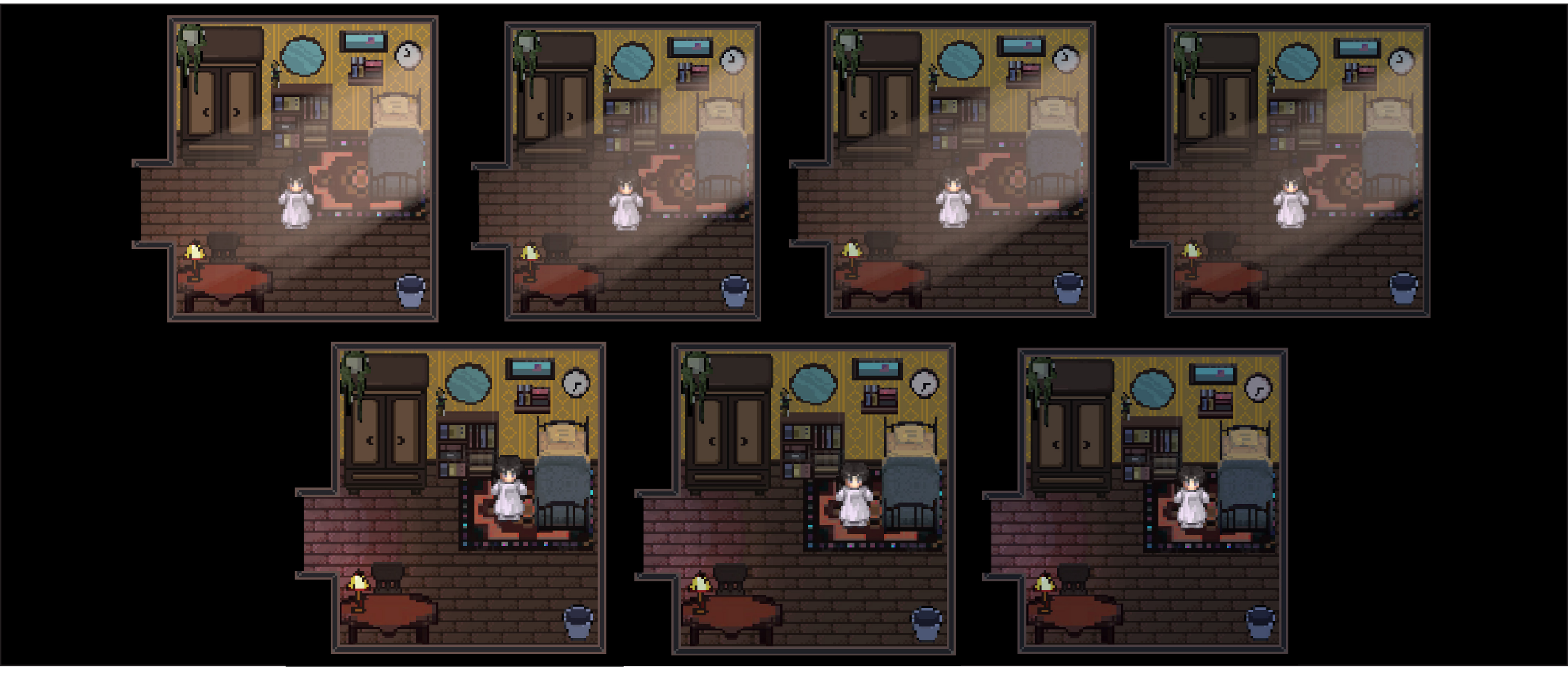
as if expected to perform without question, without hesitation,

despite the emptiness of her surroundings.

# Storytelling

## Progression

Besides the gradual creepiness of the game, another way I show progression is by the desaturation of the bedroom palette each time a dream sequence is complete.



# Storytelling

## Art

This image can be found when interacting with the picture frame in the Livingroom. It shows a crooked figure with shattered glass impaling multiple parts of their body. This creepy figure is Ophelia's future self, post-ending, after we see her jump and off the games edge and break out of her "glass box". The disturbing image is to not only shock the player, but to foreshadow the ending. I was inspired by the TV adaptation of Haunting of Hill House (The Haunting of Hill House, 2018), where character Nell is haunted her whole life by a 'bent neck lady', which is later revealed to be her deceased version of herself.

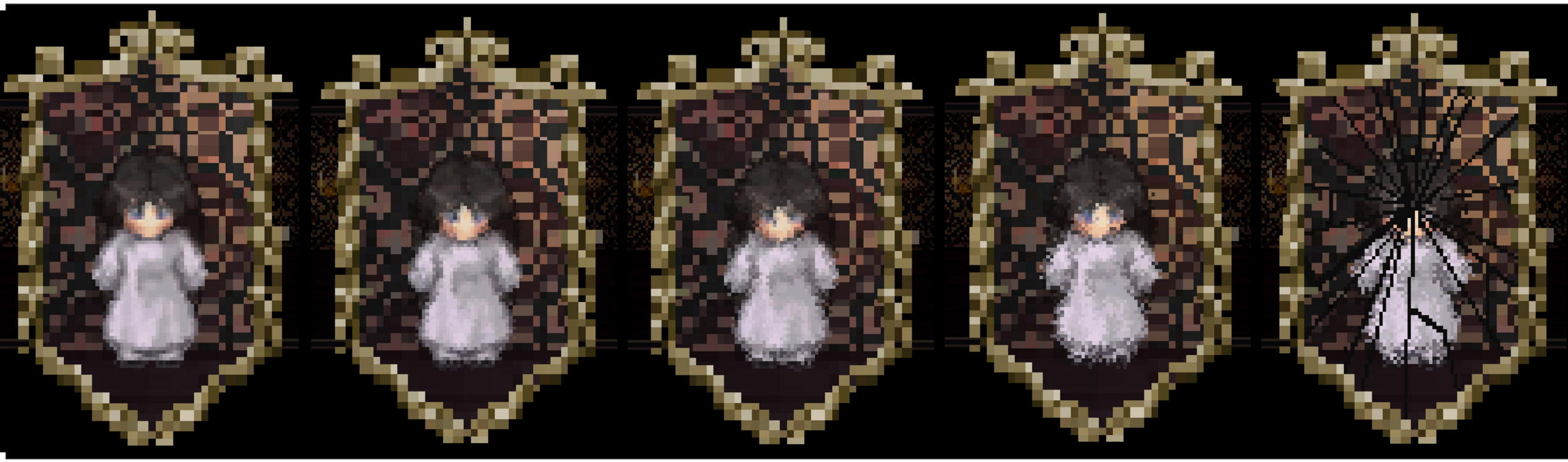


(The Haunting of Hill House, 2018)

# Storytelling

## Art

Reflections of Ophelia that are found in the hallway of mirrors progressively get more and more distorted each one the player investigates. There is also a small chance that one of the mirrors will show a shadowy figure stood behind her, giving diversity in gameplay per player. The final mirror is cracked, another symbolism of smashed glass, again alluding to the ending.



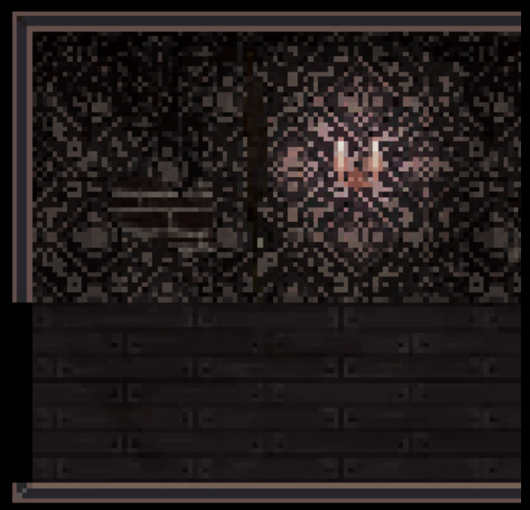
# Storytelling

## Art

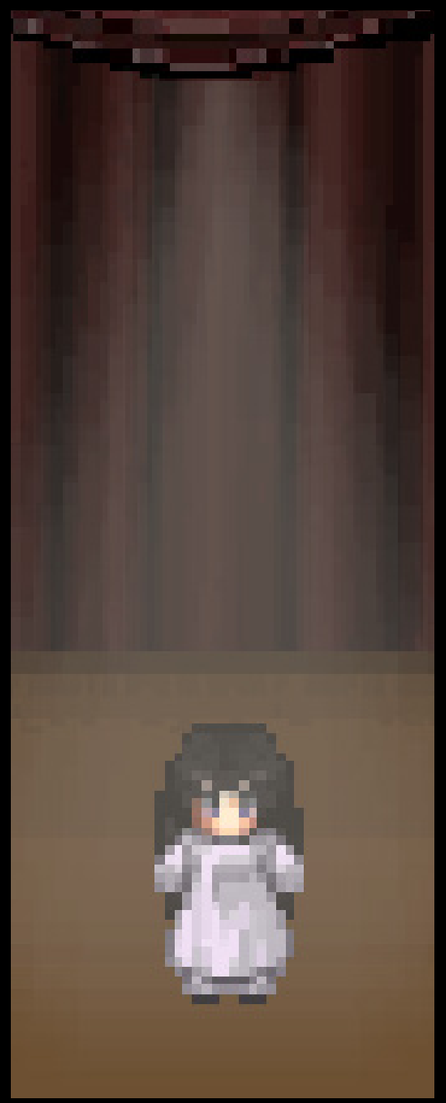
An animation featuring a collage of scary images, included a distorted version of Ophelia, plays for a short time when interacting with the teacher. This is to represent a trigger in Ophelia, her mind going to a dark place. The images accompanied with a bunch of "error" messages implies a malfunction of the game, tying Ophelia's nervous breakdown to that of the machines, breaking the fourth wall between the player and the game.













# Design

## Lighting

When designing, I used lighting as a focal point to guide the player by highlighting important areas, as well as visually enhancing environments.

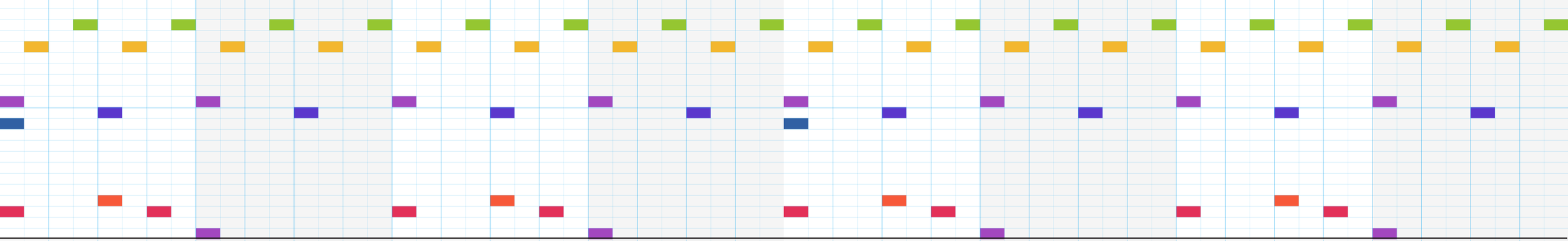
# Sprint Three

# Sound Design And Sourcing

# Title and Ending Music

At the start of this project, I had really wanted to create everything featured in this game myself, art, story, dialogue writing, coding, sound, everything from scratch. I managed to do all o9f those bar one - sound. The scope of the project was too big for me to juggle all those things. However, I managed to create one short piece that plays at the beginning and end of my game to tie it all together. Using the website *musiclab*, and the instrument piano, I made a tune based on the background music of *Pokemon Red and Blue*'s (Game Freak, 1996) 'Lavender Town'). I have no musical background, but I looked at sheet music and was able to deduce between higher and lower notes to create a similar sound.

All other sound assets were sourced on freesound.org and are credited in my weekly development journal: https://stripe-mascara-4cf.notion.site/1b6854cf14a4805f93adc779f7b5ced1?v=1b6854cf14a48115abfd000c5f7025b2&pvs=4

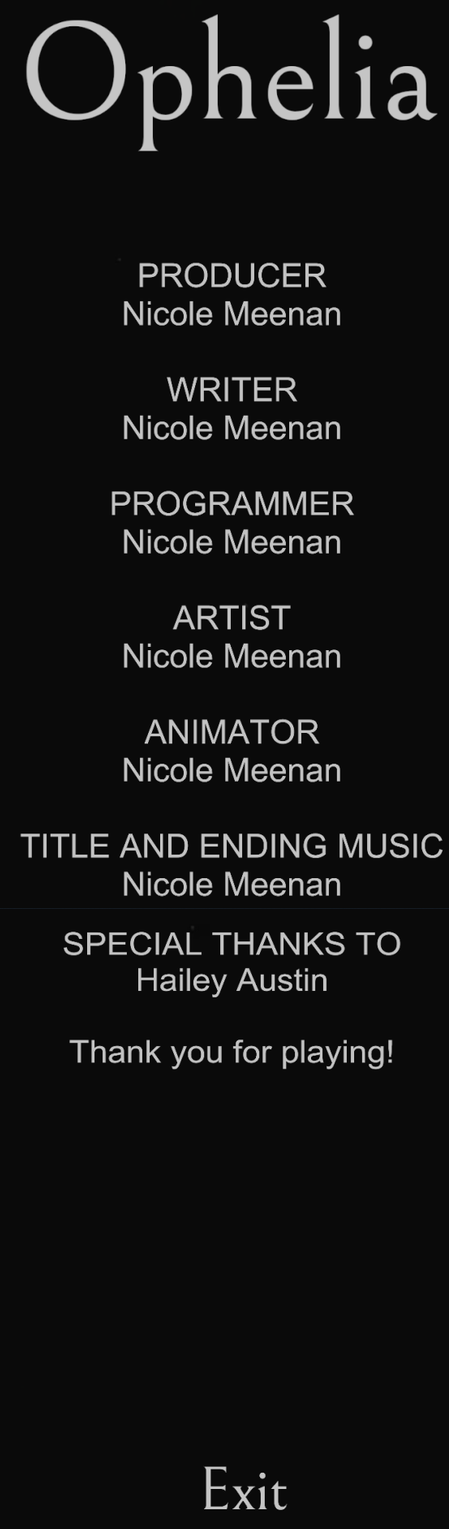


# Polishing

## Final Touches

Title and Rolling credits scenes.



```
Unity Script (2 asset references) | 0 references
public class mainMenu : MonoBehaviour
{
    0 references
    public void PlayGame()
    {
        AsyncOperation asyncOperation = SceneManager.LoadSceneAsync("Bedroom");
    }

    0 references
    public void Quit()
    {
        Application.Quit();
    }
}

public class Fader : MonoBehaviour
{
    private bool mFaded = false;

    public float Duration = 0.4f;

    Unity Message | 0 references
    private void Start()
    {
        Invoke("Fade", 5f);
    }

    0 references
    public void Fade()
    {
        var canvGroup = GetComponent<CanvasGroup>();

        StartCoroutine(DoFade(canvGroup, canvGroup.alpha, mFaded ? 0 : 1));

        mFaded = !mFaded;
    }

    1 reference
    public IEnumerator DoFade(CanvasGroup canvGroup, float start, float end)
    {
        float counter = 0f;

        while (counter < Duration)
        {
            counter += Time.deltaTime;
            canvGroup.alpha = Mathf.Lerp(start, end, counter / Duration);

            yield return null;
        }
    }

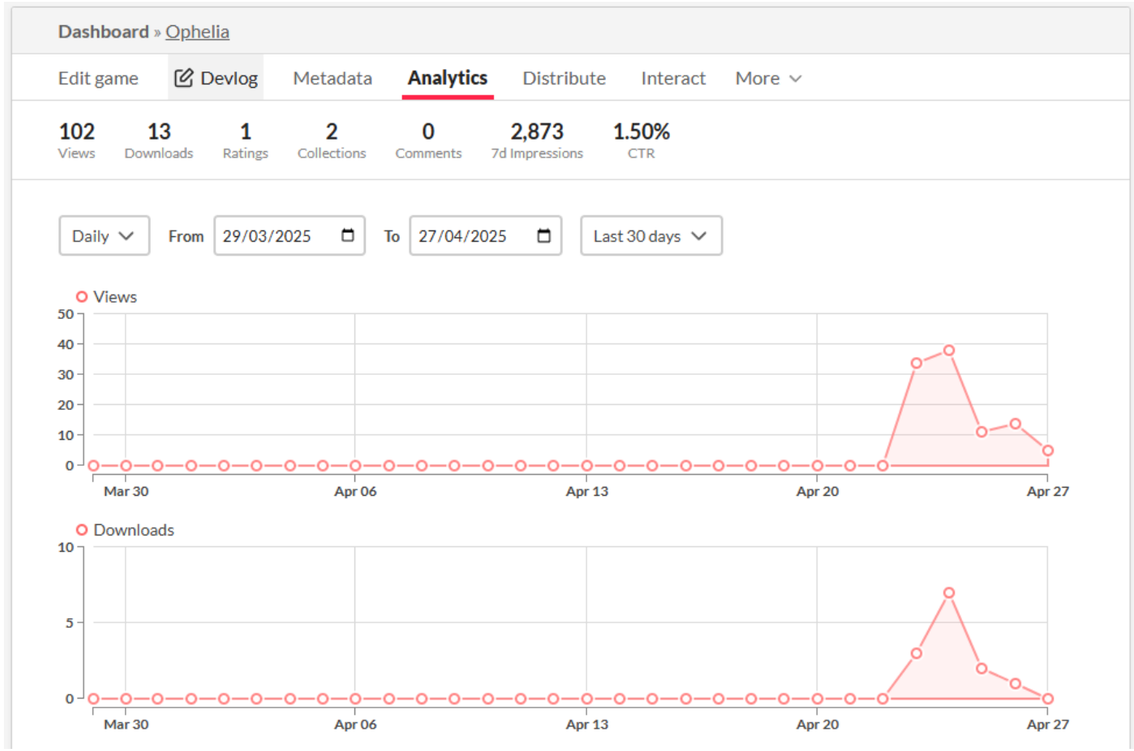

}
```

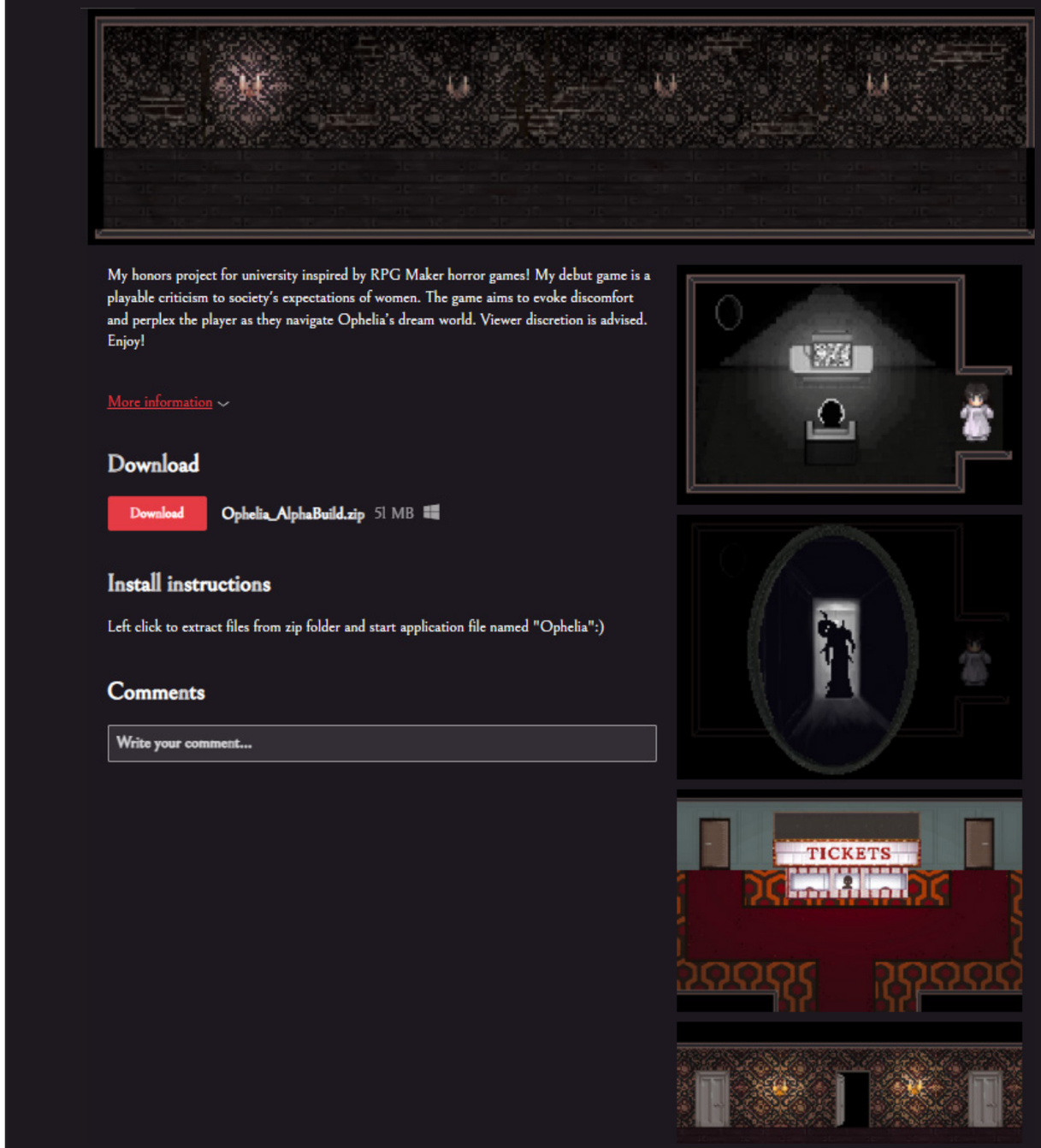
Script that contains the functionality of the menus and another that controls the fade in feature of the 'Start' and 'Quit' buttons.

# Post Production

# Publishing

On the 23rd of April I published my game on itch.io and since then it has gotten multiple downloads and even a rating from people in the community.



# Postmortem

The choice of gothic horror proved to be an effective approach for feminist storytelling (Davidson, 2009). I drew from many gothic tropes, which allowed me to portray themes of confinement, emotional vulnerability, and madness tastefully. The genres' inherent critique of societal norms made for a logical basis for a feminist game.

Pixel art pairs well with psychological and gothic horror, as seen from my inspirations. The limited detail forces the player to fill in the gaps with their imagination, complementing the genre's tendency to suggest horror rather than showing it directly (Xu, 2023).

As a solo developer, pixel art was a practical choice due to my limited skills. It gave me flexibility to maintain visual consistency throughout the game without overscoping the project.

Furthermore, pixel art has a lineage of older, male-dominated retro games. I subverted expectations through feminist storytelling in this familiar visual style.

One of my aims was to make the narrative personal and layered. I took inspiration from classic gothic texts, and similar games, and compiled them contextualised them into a narrative suitable for my game. With my limited experience in writing, I found this to be the most difficult aspect of the project. Dialogue in the game feels disconnected, whilst I am proud of my attempt, this is one thing I would improve in the future. Despite this, the themes of the game were still well-communicated, and players were able to draw their conclusions about the events of the game.



Referencing other media proved to be a successful method of enhancing players' intellectual engagement. Some testers were able to identify some of the visual references in the game, most notably *The Shining* (The Shining, 1980) carpet and the bent neck lady from the picture frame. In fact, some testers even identified the image in the picture frame as a character from another popular RPG Maker horror game, *The Crooked Man* (Uri Games, 2018). It was interesting to see how different testers interpreted events and became excited when able to identify source material, giving them a sense of discovery (Chang, 2011). For example, some testers saw the finale as a suicide whereas others viewed it as her breaking free. I never corrected any player, as there is no right or wrong answer to interpreting art; that's the beauty of it. Besides, the overarching themes of the game were always received accurately, which was my main goal.

I found that this project alone can't answer this question single-handedly, but from tester feedback suggested that expressive games centring women's experiences and serve as a gateway for those who otherwise may feel alienated by mainstream gaming culture. This was also found in my literature review (Chess, 2020).

Managing all disciplines of the game was challenging but extremely rewarding. It gave me full creative control and a deep understanding of how every element of game design works together to convey a message. I was told by my peers that my project was an over-scope, that I should refine it to focus on one discipline, so my project doesn't just subvert player expectations, but personal ones, too.

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